

# GREECE, ANCIENT



MORE THAN 2,500 YEARS AGO one of the world's most influential civilizations flowered in mainland Greece. From the 8th until the 2nd centuries BC, Greek writers, thinkers, and artists made a huge contribution to

western culture – especially in politics, drama, mythology, architecture, and literature. Greek civilization declined when, after defeating the Persians and peacefully colonizing much of Europe, they were absorbed into the Roman Empire.

## Polis

Ancient Greece was made up of hundreds of separate city-states. Some were hardly bigger than villages, while others were based around great cities, such as Sparta or Athens. Each of these city-states was known as a polis (plural: poleis). Laws, festivals, and government systems varied, and there was often war between rival poleis, despite their common Greek background. The need for land led some poleis to colonize other parts of the Mediterranean between the 8th and 6th centuries BC, and in this way ancient Greece expanded.



### Sparta

Life in Sparta was disciplined and harsh. Spartans trained both girls and boys to excel at sports and feats of endurance. To strengthen military power, all the boys went on to become soldiers. After helping Athens defeat the Persians in 480 BC, Sparta conquered Athens in the Peloponnesian War (431–404 BC), and became master of Greece.

Ancient Greece, c.4th century BC



## Mount Olympus

Ancient Greeks believed that various deities (gods and goddesses) watched over ordinary mortals from a cloud-palace above the highest mountain in Greece – the snow-capped Mount Olympus. The deities who lived there were also known as Olympians. Each Olympian had specific responsibilities: Poseidon was in charge of the sea, Athena of wisdom and the arts, Apollo of music and poetry, and Demeter of crops. The supreme god was Zeus, lord of sky and earth. Greek cities regarded different deities as their special protectors. For example, Athens was devoted to the cult of Athena.



### Clash of the Titans

The Greeks believed that the world was originally inhabited by giants called Titans. Their ruler, Cronos, swallowed his children alive, so that they could not overthrow him. One son, Zeus, escaped this fate when his mother gave Cronos a clothed stone to swallow instead. Zeus grew up in secret, made Cronos vomit up his siblings, defeated the other Titans in battle, and made himself king of the gods.

Cronos eating his children

### Oracle at Delphi

Ancient Greeks consulted the gods for advice or prophecies at holy places called oracles. The most famous oracle in Greece was at Delphi. People went there to ask questions at Apollo's shrine about religious or political matters. A high priestess went into a trance to give Apollo's answers. Most gods had their special shrine, but they competed with each other for the best ones. Legend has it that Athena won a competition against Poseidon over the Parthenon in Athens, the largest city in Greece, and he had to move his shrine to Attica.

Poseidon, god of the sea

Poseidon was Zeus's brother and god of the sea.

Poseidon is usually shown holding a fish.



Part of a trident

### Athens

From the 6th century BC, Athens was governed by a form of democracy (rule by the people), in which all male citizens voted. In the 5th century BC, thanks to its powerful navy, Athens had a maritime empire in the Aegean Sea, and its 250,000-strong population enjoyed a golden age of art and culture. After their triumph against the Persians, the Athenians celebrated by building a massive "fortified citadel" – the Acropolis. The Parthenon (447 and 432 BC) was the most important temple in the Acropolis, and was dedicated to Athena.

Spartan warrior



Red marble tiles covered the roof.

The Parthenon

Coloured frieze

White marble columns

Reliefs decorated the exterior.

Temples were built on stepped platforms.

### The Legend of Troy

Little of the ancient city of Troy (in modern Turkey) remains. Homer's *Iliad* says that a Greek army besieged Troy for 10 years in the late Mycenaean Age (c.1250 BC). This became known as the Trojan War. According to legend, Athena advised the Greeks to smuggle their soldiers into the city inside a huge wooden horse, and in this way they gained victory.



Model of Trojan Horse

### Homer

The Greek poet Homer probably lived in the 7th or 8th century BC. He is believed to be the author of two of the world's greatest epic poems: the *Iliad*, which is about the siege of Troy, and the *Odyssey*, which describes the wanderings of the hero Odysseus after the Trojan War. According to later writers, Homer was blind.

